POLSCI 367 Authoritarian Politics
Fall [Year]
Tuesdays 1-4PM, Gross 105

Instructor: Trung-Anh Nguyen
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Office Hours: Tuesdays and Thursdays 4-5PM

Course Overview

Conventional wisdom often frames democracies as inherently good and autocracies as inherently bad—but what does it mean for an autocracy to be "bad"? This course will investigate what constitutes an authoritarian regime, how they emerge and break down, how they differ, the particular governance challenges they face, and the tools they use to endure.

This seminar offers a thematic approach to the study of comparative authoritarian politics. Questions of interest include, but are not limited to: How do dictators deal with challenges from within their inner circle and from the masses? When do autocracies break down? Do elections affect authoritarian rule? How has technological change influenced autocratic governance? How do citizens' preferences or public opinion come to play in an authoritarian context?

We will cover classical theories of authoritarian rule as well as the current literature on comparative authoritarianism. Throughout, we will also build empirical knowledge about the politics of particular authoritarian regimes.

Prerequisites

The course is designed for advanced undergraduate students in the social sciences. Required: (1) Junior standing and above; (2) a previous course in political science. Recommended: One semester of probability or statistics (STATS 220 or equivalent) and concurrent or prior training in game theory (ECON 222 or equivalent).

Learning Objectives

- Understand how autocracies differ from democracies and the different types of autocracies
- Obtain a strong foundation in the existing scholarship on authoritarian politics
- Can critically engage with this literature, including identifying areas for further research
- Develop a detailed understanding of the institutional structures, governance strategies, and challenges faced by a specific authoritarian regime
- Enhance public speaking and presentation abilities through the in-class presentation
- Be able to formulate an original research proposal that is grounded in the literature

Assessments

1. *Attendance and Participation* (20%): Participation includes both regular attendance in class and thoughtful contribution to class discussion.

Additionally, before 5PM the day before class, each student is expected to post three discussion questions/comments on the readings under the "Discussion" tab for that week on Canvas.

2. *White Paper* (15%) and *Presentation* (10%): A 1,500-word paper discussing an authoritarian regime of your choice. The paper should summarize the key institutional facts of your case and focus on one or more of the thematic areas from the course syllabus. You will then each do a 15-minute presentation of your chosen case to the class.
   We will have at least one student per week do the white paper and present that week. A signup sheet will be circulated on the first day of class. The paper is due 5PM the day before the class you signed up to present.
3. *Midterm* (25%): In-class exam with essay questions.
4. *Final Paper* (30%): Write a 5,000-to-7,000-word paper on either (1) a review article that provides a critical overview of existing findings in a sub-literature of authoritarian politics and propose a new research agenda and questions; or (2) an original research paper on a topic in authoritarian politics with an empirical component.

   Your topic, extended abstract, and bibliography (option 1) or research question, extended abstract, and bibliography (option 2) are due on **October 3 at 11:59pm**. This assignment is worth 20% of your final paper grade.

   You will also give a conference-style presentation on your final paper during the last week of class. This part is worth 10% of your final paper grade.

   Your final paper is due on **December 10 at 11:59pm**. The submitted final paper is worth 70% of your final paper grade.

Additional instructions for each assignment will be posted on Canvas. Please upload all written assignments to Canvas.

Main texts: (Required)

1. Svolik, Milan. 2012. *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule*. New York: Cambridge University Press. (Marked as "Svolik")
2. Geddes, Barbara, Joseph Wright, and Erica Frantz. 2018. *How Dictatorships Work: Power, Personalization, and Collapse*. New York: Cambridge University Press. (Marked as "GWF")

All other readings, unless specifically noted, can be found under the 'Files' tab and the relevant week on the course's Canvas site. I expect you to undertake the readings prior to the class session for which they are listed.

Grading scale

A: 95-100; A-: 90-94.9; B+: 87.9-89.9; B: 83.33-87.8; B-: 80-83.32; FAIL: 0-79.9

Technology Policies and Academic Support

Please do not use your cell phones during class and limit your laptop use to referencing articles/readings and typing notes (if that is your preference).

Some resources:

- Academic Resource Center: Find tutors, build your academic skills.
- Thompson Writing Program: Schedule an appointment to discuss ways to improve as a writer.
- Student Disability Access Office (SDAO): For registration of accommodation needs and any other support.
- Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS): Make counseling appointments and seek referrals to outside therapists.
- TimelyCare (formerly Blue Devils Care): Convenient, confidential, and free online mental health support.

Disability Accommodation

Students with a documented disability should present me with their accommodation letter from the SDAO (see resources above) at their earliest convenience. This letter allows me to follow university policy that accommodates disabilities while also protecting student privacy. Students who need to obtain a letter are encouraged to reach out to SDAO as soon as possible and make sure that their instructor is informed that a letter can be expected at a later date.

Academic Integrity

Duke University is a community dedicated to scholarship, leadership, and service and to the principles of honesty, fairness, respect, and accountability. Citizens of this community commit to reflect upon and uphold these principles in all academic and non-academic endeavors, and to protect and promote a culture of integrity. To uphold the Duke Community Standard:

- I will not lie, cheat, or steal in my academic endeavors;
- I will conduct myself honorably in all my endeavors; and
- I will act if the Standard is compromised.

Course Schedule

Week 1 (Aug. 28): Conceptualization & Measurement Issues

- Schmitter, P. C., & Karl, T. L. 1991. "What democracy is... and is not." *Journal of Democracy*, 2(3): 75-88.
- Cheibub, Jose Antonio, Jennifer Gandhi, and James Vreeland. 2010. "Democracy and dictatorship revisited." *Public Choice* 143: 67–101
- Coopedge et al. 2011. "Conceptualizing and Measuring Democracy: A New Approach." *Perspectives on Politics* 9(1): 247-67
- Diamond, Larry. 2002. "Thinking about hybrid regimes." *Journal of Democracy*, 13(2): 21–35.

Week 2 (Sept. 4): Typologies

- Geddes, Barbara. 1999. "What do we know about democratization after twenty years?" *Annual Review of Political Science* 2(1):115-144.
- Levitsky, Steven & Lucan Way. 2002. "The Rise of Competitive Authoritarianism." *Journal of Democracy* 13(1): 51-65.
- Svolik, Chapter 2.
- Geddes, Barbara, Joseph Wright, and Erica Frantz. 2014. "Autocratic Breakdown and Regime Transitions: A New Dataset." *Perspective on Politics*. 12(2): 313-331.

Week 3 (Sept. 11): Personalism & Power Concentration

- Svolik, Chapter 3
- GWF, Chapters 4 & 5.
- Gandhi, Jennifer, and Jane Lawrence Sumner. 2020. "Measuring the consolidation of power in nondemocracies." *The Journal of Politics* 82.4, 1545-1558.

Week 4 (Sept. 18): Coups and Military Rule

- Roessler, Philip. 2011. "The enemy within: Personal rule, coups, and civil war in Africa." *World Politics* 63(2): 300-346.
- Geddes, Barbara, Erica Frantz, and Joseph Wright. 2014. "Military Rule." *Annual Review of Political Science.* 17(1): 147-162.
- Marinov, Nikolay, and Hein Goemans. 2014. "Coups and democracy." *British Journal of Political Science* 44(4): 799-825.

Week 5 (Sept. 25): Institutions

- Gandhi, Jennifer. 2008. *Political Institutions under Dictatorship*. New York: Cambridge University Press. Chapters 3 & 6.
- Svolik, Chapter 4.
- Pepinsky, Thomas. 2014. "The Institutional Turn in Comparative Authoritarianism." *British Journal of Political Science.* 44(3): 631-653.

Week 6 (Oct. 2): Political Parties

- Magaloni, Beatriz. 2007. *Voting for Autocracy: Hegemonic Party Survival and its Demise in Mexico*. New York: Cambridge University Press. Chapters 1-5.
- Svolik, Chapter 6.
- GWF, Chapter 5.

EXTENDED ABSTRACT DUE OCT 3 BY 11:59PM

FALL BREAK

Week 7 (Oct. 16): Elections

- Gandhi, Jennifer and Ellen Lust. 2009. "Elections Under Authoritarianism." *Annual Review of Political Science* 12: 403-422.
- Knutsen, Carl Henrik, Havard Mokleiv Nygard and Tore Wig. 2017. "Autocratic Elections: Stabilizing Tool or Force for Change?" *World Politics* 69.1: 98-143.
- GWF, Chapter 6.
- Morgenbesser, Lee, and Thomas B. Pepinsky. 2019. "Elections as Causes of Democratization: Southeast Asia in Comparative Perspective." *Comparative Political Studies* 52(1) 3–35

Week 8 (Oct. 23): Repression

- Svolik, Chapter 5.
- GWF, Chapter 7.
- Ong, Lynette H. 2018. "'Thugs-for-Hire': Subcontracting of state coercion and state capacity in China." *Perspectives on Politics* 16.3 (2018): 680-695.

Week 9 (Oct. 30): IN-CLASS MIDTERM

Week 10 (Nov. 6): Information and Authoritarian Control

- King, Gary, Jennifer Pan, and Margaret E. Roberts. 2013. "How censorship in China allows government criticism but silences collective expression." *American Political Science Review* 107(2): 326-343.
- Gunitsky, Seva. 2015. "Corrupting the cyber-commons: Social media as a tool of autocratic stability" *Perspectives on Politics* 13(1): 42-54.
- Hollyer, James R., B. Peter Rosendorff, and James Raymond Vreeland. 2015. "Transparency, protest, and autocratic instability." *American Political Science Review* 109(4): 764-784.
- Manion. 2015. *Information for Autocrats*. New York: Cambridge University Press. pp. 1-77.

Week 11 (Nov. 13): Accountability and Responsiveness

- Tsai, Lily. 2007. "Solidary Groups, Informal Accountability, and Local Public Goods Provision in Rural China." *American Political Science Review*, vol.101, no.2: 355-372.
- Malesky, Edmund and Paul, Schuler. 2010. "Nodding or Needling: Analyzing Delegate Responsiveness in an Authoritarian Parliament," *American Political Science Review* 104(3): 482-502.
- Chen, Jidong, Jennifer Pan, and Yiqing Xu. 2015. "Sources of Authoritarian Responsiveness: A Field Experiment in China." *American Journal of Political Science.*

Week 12 (Nov. 20): Protest and Authoritarian Breakdown

- GWF, Chapter 8.
- Kuran, Timur. "Now Out of Never: The Element of Surprise in the East European Revolution of 1989." *World Politics* 44.1 (1991): 7-48.
- Treisman, Daniel. 2015. "Income, Democracy, and Leader Turnover." *American Journal of Political Science*
- Lorentzen, Peter. 2013. "Regularizing Rioting: Permitting Public Protest in an Authoritarian Regime." *Quarterly Journal of Political Science* 8 (2): 127-158.

Week 13 (Dec. 4): Student Presentations

FINAL PAPER DUE DEC 10 BY 11:59PM